AI "GIRLFRIENDS" / COMPANIONS:

A PARENT'S PLAIN-ENGLISH GUIDE

AI companions are chat apps or websites that create romantic or close relationships using artificial intelligence. They can feel real. They can feel comforting.

Here's what parents need to know.

3.1M people worldwide use AI companion apps (2024) — Sensor Tower

71% of users are male — Business Insider

58 MINS average daily time spent — Data.ai (2024)

1 WHAT IT IS

AI chat apps that simulate a romantic partner or close companion.

2 HOW IT WORKS

You chat with an AI. It learns your style and responds in real time.

3 FEATURES

Roleplay, voice chat, images, memories and personalised conversations.

4 CONTROLS

Account settings, content filters and blocking – but limits vary.

5 RISKS

Emotional dependence, inappropriate content, privacy and spending.

6 CONVERSATION

Talk early. Listen often. Keep it open and judgement-free.

WHAT ARE AI COMPANIONS?

Natural chat
Text or voice conversations that feel personal.

Romantic roleplay
Flirty or romantic interactions and storylines.

Image generation
Create or receive AI-generated images.

Memory & learning
Remembers details about you over time.

Always available
Chat 24/7. Never busy. Always responds.

Customisable
Looks, personality and backstory can be customised.

WHAT PARENTS NEED TO UNDERSTAND

1. **It's not a real person.**
AI companions are designed to please and keep you engaged.

2. **It can feel real.**
The connection can feel strong and even addictive.

3. **It's a fast-growing space.**
New apps and features appear all the time.

BY THE NUMBERS

20% of teens say they have used an AI companion app or site — Pew Research (2024)

$120+ average monthly spend by heavy users — Business Insider (2024)

2X more likely to use late at night (11pm–6am) — Data.ai (2024)

200% Increase in AI companion app downloads in 2023–2024 — Sensor Tower

SAFETY FEATURES / SETTINGS

WHAT EXISTS

- **Content filters** Limit explicit or adult content.
- **Privacy controls** Control what's stored and shared.
- **Block & report** Block users and report issues.
- **Delete data** Some apps let you clear your data.

WHAT TO CHANGE

- Enable content filters.
- Review privacy settings.
- Limit image generation.
- Turn off memory if possible.
- Set spending limits.

STEP-BY-STEP SAFETY GUIDE

1. **Research the app.** Read reviews. Check age ratings and terms.
2. **Check privacy settings.** Review what data is collected and stored.
3. **Turn on safety features.** Enable filters and limit image generation.
4. **Set time and spending limits.** Use device tools or app limits.
5. **Talk about it.** Keep the conversation open and regular.
6. **Review together.** Check in often and adjust as needed.

THE RISKS WORTH KNOWING

- **Emotional Dependence** May rely on AI instead of real-life relationships.
- **Inappropriate Content** Risk of explicit or sexual content.
- **Privacy Risks** Your child's data and chats may be stored.
- **Financial Costs** In-app purchases and subscriptions add up.
- **Distorted Expectations** Unrealistic ideas about love and relationships.
- **Isolation** May withdraw from friends and family.

THE 10-MINUTE CONVERSATION

- What do you like about the app?
- How does it make you feel?
- Do you feel it affects your mood or sleep?
- Is there anything that worries you about it?

TRUST OVER SURVEILLANCE
Connection builds safety.

IF THINGS GO WRONG

STAY CALM & GATHER EVIDENCE

- Listen calmly.
- Save messages or screenshots.
- Note dates, times and what happened.
- Do not delete evidence.

REPORT & SEEK HELP

- Use the app's report and block tools.
- Talk to a trusted adult.
- Contact Childline if you need support.
- Get help from school if needed.

You did the right thing. Help is available.

NEED TO TALK? CHILDLINE | **0800 1111** childline.org.uk | **YOU ARE NOT ALONE** We're here for you.